

SOCIETY & TRENDS
E-SPORTS

GIRL GAMERS TO THE FORE

AROUND 40 PER CENT OF INDIA'S 500 MILLION GAMERS ARE NOW ESTIMATED TO BE WOMEN, WITH MANY GOING PRO, WINNING HUGE AUDIENCES, SPONSORSHIPS AND TOURNAMENTS

By **SUHANI SINGH**

As kids, when **Saloni Pawar**, 26, used to see her elder brother Sukrut while away hours on the computer every day playing a gory shooter—CounterStrike 1.6—she would wonder, "What's this stupid guy doing just killing people?" She preferred Barbie, a videogame she was an expert in and that featured far less bloodshed and more sunshine. One day, though, intrigued by her brother's manic devotion to his game, she decided to give it a try; she was a natural. "Girls don't even play videogames," she remembered her brother remarking nervously, aghast at her high score.

This may have been true a decade or two back. Today, female players are an integral part of India's growing gaming ecosystem. According to Niko Partners' India Gamer Behavior and Market Insights, of the estimated 500 million gamers in the country in late 2025, around 40 per cent are women, up from 22 per cent five years before. A FICCI-EY 2025 report confirms the trend,